

The Voice

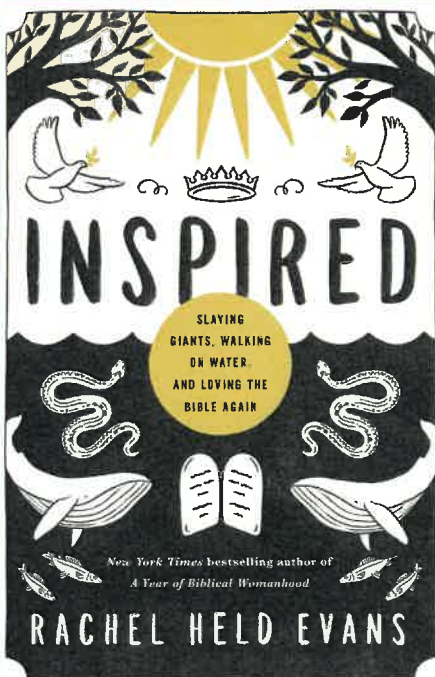
July 2024

A NEWSLETTER FOR MEMBERS AND FRIENDS OF FIRST EVANGELICAL LUTHERAN CHURCH

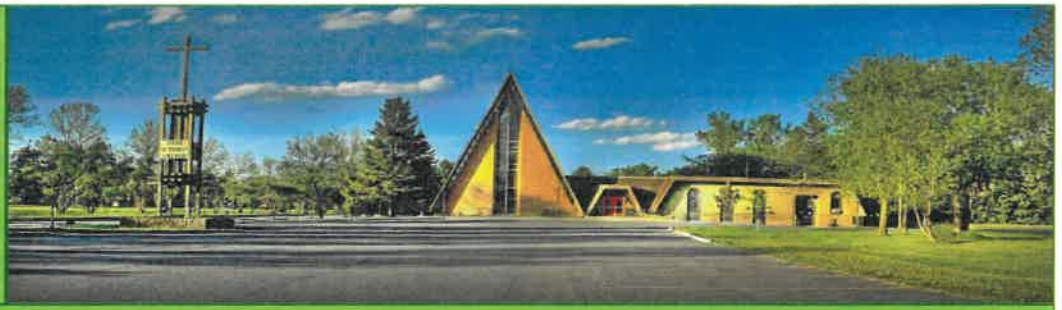
A Congregation of the
Northeastern
Minnesota Synod, ELCA



Bake Sale replaces
Christmas in July.
See page 5.



Book recommendation -
See page 9.



Joint Vacation Bible School a hit with everyone involved

More pictures can be found on page 8.



Thank you to all the people who helped the kids have such a great experience. It means more than you know.

From the Pastor's Desk

A blessed July everyone!

As I write this there is yet another thunderstorm coming into the Falls. The rain, it seems, has been a constant companion so far this summer. While I am not usually one to complain about the weather, I found myself on the verge of whining when I opened my weather app and saw the forecast. That stopped quickly, of course, when photos from Cook, MN, and all the flooding they have been dealing with was the next thing to come across my feed. In reflecting on my reactions to all of the above, I began to wonder...what if there was a different way to consider weather? Like, what if I began to see "the weather" as part of a spiritual practice rather than something to either complain about or use as a conversation filler as we do?

Weather, after all, is an integral part of God's creation and something we humans are connected to deeply (and not just because it changes our plans). I did a little digging and lo and behold my favorite blog, "Spirituality and Practice", did a piece this month on just this subject, and they did it so well, I'm sharing parts of it below. I pray that you might find it useful and, whatever the weather, that you find some peace and goodness to connect to as this summer moves along. And to that end, I pray you are finding places to connect with God in this season, whether that is in church, at the cabin, on the lake, in the rain or sun, or wherever your heart takes you in these beautiful long days.

**Your friend in Christ,
Pastor Christie**

How to See Your Connection to the Weather: The world-famous Catholic monk Thomas Merton sets the tone for our spiritual weather strategies in this passage from "When the Trees Say Nothing", a collection of his writings on nature edited by Kathleen Deignan.

Our mentioning the weather — our perfunctory observations on what kind of day it is, are perhaps not idle. Perhaps we have a deep and legitimate need to know in our entire being what the day is like, to see it and feel it, to know how the sky is grey, paler in the south, patches of blue in the southwest with snow on the ground, the thermometer at 18, and cold wind making your ears ache. I have a real need to know these things because I myself am part of the weather, and part of the climate and part of the place, and a day in which I have not shared truly in all this is no day at all. It is certainly part of my life of prayer. "We like the challenge of seeing the weather as deeply and intimately connected to us. We see the heat or the cold as part of our experience of the day, which we cannot change or ignore. It has an effect upon us and we reflect it in our thoughts, words, and deeds. We once asked an Antiguan how he was, and he said: "Partly cloudy, chance of rain."

Make it a practice to relate to the weather. Let it be a metaphor for you. For example, on hot days, be "heated up" with passion for your work or some other aspect of your life.

Don't Curse the Heat: Use It as an Opportunity to Pray for Others. One of the things about heat waves is that we often get so wrapped up in our own state of vexation that we forget the genuine and wide-spread suffering of others. So the next time you find yourself falling into this self-absorption trap, say a few prayers for all those who have been adversely affected by the heat: the elderly who have been stricken by heart attacks, the poor who have no access to air-conditioning, the lonely and isolated individuals imprisoned in small rooms, the animals who have not been given enough water, the plants that are wilting in the sun.

Accept All Weather as Weather We Like

The Catholic priest Anthony De Mello tells a story that sums up the best way to live with any kind of weather:

Traveler: What kind of weather are we going to have today?

Traveler: How do you know it will be the kind of weather you like?

Shepherd: Having found out, sir, I cannot always get what I like, I have learned always to like what I get. So I am quite sure we will have the kind of weather I like.

source: <https://www.spiritualityandpractice.com/>

First Evangelical Lutheran Church Council Meeting

May 19, 2024

Present: President Brian Briggs, Secretary Carol Bass, Pastor Christie Manisto, Treasurer Brad Ettestad, Building & Grounds Lloyd Skogstad, Fellowship Cynthia Warren, Outreach Brenda Bertilson, Discipleship BettyJeanne Henrickson

Meeting called to order by President Brian Briggs the morning of May 19th at Camp Vermillion retreat.

Opening Devotional: Pastor Manisto

Next Month: Cynthia Warren

Additions to Agenda: None

Approve minutes of April 2024:

Motion: To approve the minutes of April 2024 as presented.

Made by: Brenda Bertilson Seconded by: Cynthia Warren

Passed

Approve Financial Reports of April 2024: Financially okay this month and we have reserves. Continue to monitor expenses. In the process of forming a stewardship committee. Keep the congregation mindful of finances. The synod has some stewardship ideas.

Pastor's Report April 18-May 19:

One memorial service coming in June. VBS will be 8:30 to 1:00. Pastor will be going to Camp Vermillion one day to lead theology class for counselors.

Pastoral acts

☐ Led worship.

☐ visitation and pastoral care phone calls, meetings and cards for members

☐ Bible study and book study

☐ 1 new member classes (reception on May 12th)

☐ Council retreat at Camp Vermillion

☐ Met with joint councils from First and Zion Fort Frances for future planning.

Community

☐ Continuing to serve as part of the Rotary welcoming community team. Meetings continue.

☐ Part of an ELCA cohort group meeting on Thursdays each week for 1 hour.

☐ taking a class on Thursday from Wartburg seminary called dialog works on transitions in ministry.

Youth

☐ Sent 2 first family's newsletters.

☐ Confirmation classes including a visit to

Servants of Shelter

☐ "Senior Sunday" to honor our graduating seniors on May 5th.

☐ Met with BettyJeanne and Katie Winkel for VBS planning.

Synod

☐ Pastor's text study Trinity in Cook

☐ Mutual ministry meeting in Cook

☐ Attended synod assembly with Steve our voting member on April 27th (all day)

Admin

☐ Committee meetings (finance, building and grounds, care corps etc.)

☐ ELCA synod journey training on group leadership and racism.

☐ Finished transition in ministry class with Kathi

☐ Attended the "new to the synod" meeting in Duluth with the bishop and synod staff.

Personal

☐ Spent time with family at the beginning of May.

Steve has been hired to work at Falls Elementary starting in September

Community

☐ 1 Kooch aging board meeting

3 welcoming committee events (including providing leadership on the topic of welcoming refugees and immigrants to International Falls

☐ volunteered at Ruby's pantry.

(Council, continued on page 4)

Reverend Christie Manisto

Office Hours:

Monday—Thursday

10 a.m. – 2 p.m.

Friday

9 a.m. to noon

218-283-2208

www.firstlutheranifalls.org

firstlutheranifalls@gmail.com

Council (continued from page 3)

Upcoming

- ☐ VBS June 10-14
- ☐ Lead session on Theology for VLM staff on June 11
- ☐ Presentation on forced migration for World Refugee Day at St. Scholastica

Committee Reports:

a. President – Thank you to everyone who came to the retreat. It was a great weekend. Am excited to be moving forward with the ideas shared and possibilities with Zion Ft Frances.

b. Vice-President Office vacant

c. Service/Outreach: 4 volunteers at Café, 4 cards sent to ill/shut ins.

3 prayer requests initiated. Still looking for ideas for God's Work Our Hands projects, Helping Hands pantry is stocked. Did pew check for pencils and envelopes.

d. Discipleship – Vacation Bible School the second week of June.

Doing a review of what worked last year and what didn't. Youth to New Orleans have raised \$2,000 more than needed which will be used in case of emergencies or for next convention. The money will be on direct account cards to use on trip. Confirmation materials will need to be replenished next year.

e. Fellowship – Had two cake Sundays, one for graduating seniors and the other for new members. Workday in June will have brats, beans, potato salad, desserts for after meal. Cynthia will be cooking on site.

f. Building & Grounds – Workday plans finalized. The two pull-down ladders are here and will be installed. Planters are here and flowers will be added. May be moved near trees and add benches.

Requesting quote on building insurance and checking out new company. Looking for one more quote on roofing replacement. The Facility Use Agreement needs updating and revision. The carpet in Pastor's office may be done in July while she is with youth in New Orleans. Bathrooms in church could use some updating. AED training held for council.

g. Finance: Nothing further

h. Worship and Music – no report.

Old Business:

a. Review of Zion Ft Frances visit went very well and positive. We will be arranging further meetings to discuss a possible covenant with them. Brian will be doing temple talks to

keep the congregation informed of progress and to answer any questions. Also include that this might involve a change in service times to allow enough time for Pastor to go back and forth. Pastor also discussed having a sunrise service for the summer beginning at 7:30/8:00. It would be abbreviated with no sermon but would include communion. Service would be like the noon Lenten services.

b. Employment reviews will be held in August for Kris and Kathi.

They will fill out a self-review form prior to then. After this year, reviews will be in January.

New Business:

a. Pride Parade – Pastor will join the walkers at the Pride Parade walk to Ft Frances at 10:30 on June 15th.

b. Pastor will need time off in August 2025 when she will officiate at a friend's wedding.

c. Chamber of Commerce membership – do we wish to renew? Cost is \$100 and benefits are the C of C will include us in their events and promote us.

Motion: To renew C of C membership at a cost of \$100.

Made by: Lloyd Skogstad

Seconded by: Brad Ettestad

Passed

Adjourned

Respectfully submitted by:

Carol Bass, Secretary

Next Executive Committee Meeting: June 18th, 2024, at 5 PM





Start planning for July 31st Crazy Bake Sale



Crazy Daze are just around the corner, and so is the ladies' Crazy Daze Bake Sale. This is a great time to dig out those recipes and patterns. Produce is also very welcome. This is all happening on Wednesday, July 31st from 10-1. Save the date!

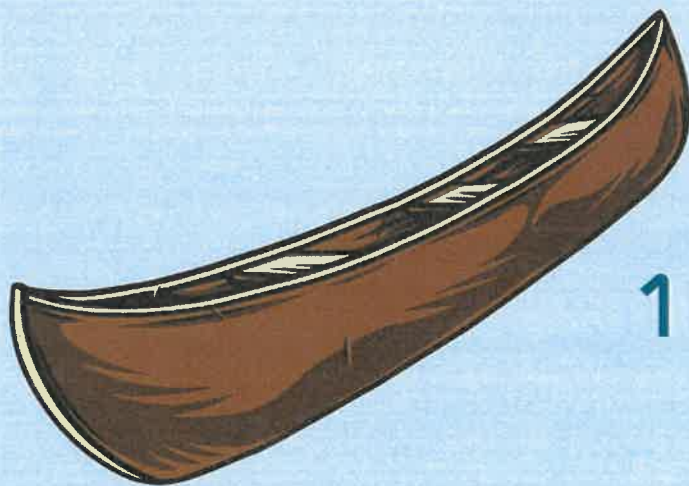
School kits supplies needed for World Relief

The First Lutheran Women are preparing school kits again this year. Please watch for sales on school supplies in July and August for notebooks, crayons, scissors, rulers, and pencil sharpeners. The items most needed are notebooks as there are 4 in each kit. These are distributed by Lutheran World Relief in the US and around the world.



**CALLING ALL 6-12TH GRADE
YOUTH AND ADULTS !
WE ARE GOING ON A
CANOE DAY TRIP!**

**SAT.
AUGUST
17**



10:00 AM-3:00 PM
MEET AT FIRST
LUTHERAN CHURCH.
LUNCH, PADDLES PFD'S
AND CANOES INCLUDED!



LUNCH *
CANOEING*
FRIENDS*
FUN!

Sign up by Aug 1 with Pastor Christie or in the church
office!

HOUSEBOAT *Party*

Join First Lutheran for a fun
afternoon of fellowship on the Briggs
houseboat!

SATURDAY, JULY 27TH 1:00 PM



Admission:
free will
donation



BYOB!



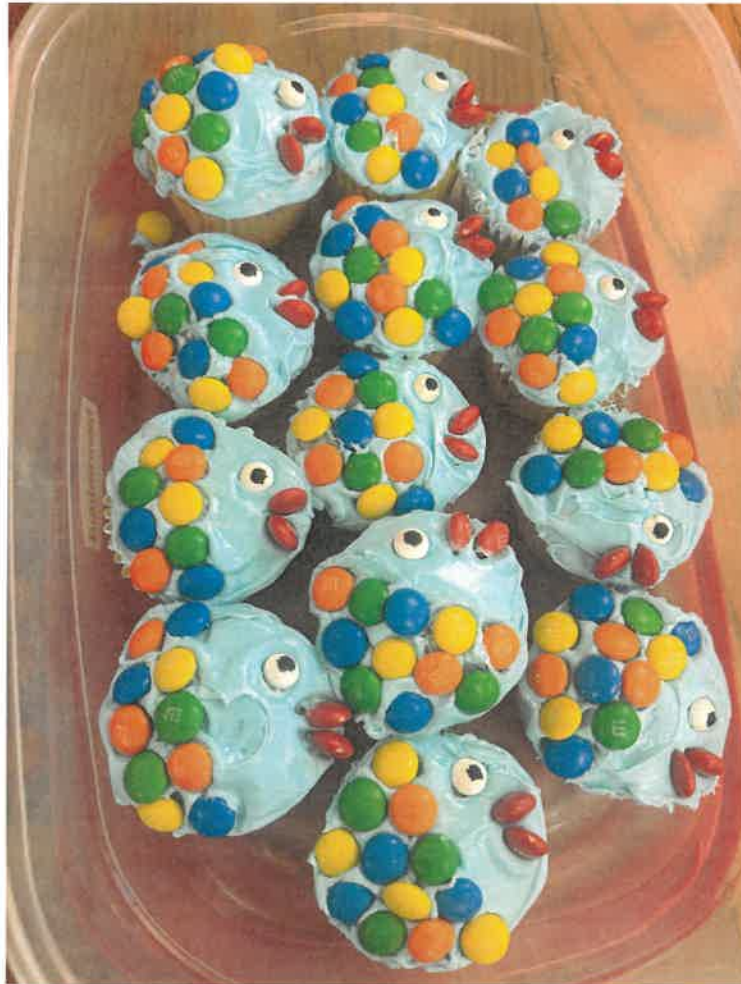
1:00 PM Start



parking is
limited ride
share is
encouraged!

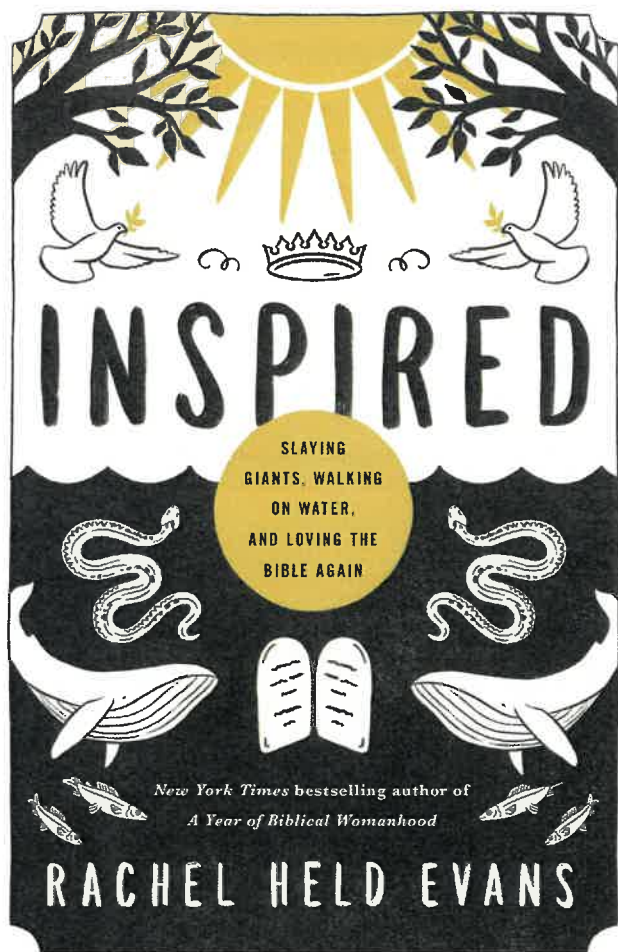
**PLEASE SIGN UP IN THE CHURCH OFFICE! SPACE
IS LIMITED TO 30 PARTICIPANTS!**

First Lutheran Youth: What's Up?



All the best parts of any VBS-week experience: crafts, snacks, and games. Thanks to everyone who took part!





Book recommendation: *Inspired* by Rachel Held Evans

Evans knows firsthand how a relationship with the Bible can be as real and as complicated as a relationship with a family member or close friend. In *Inspired*, Evans explores contradictions and questions from her own experiences with the Bible, including:

- If the Bible was supposed to explain the mysteries of life, why does it leave the reader with so many questions?
- What does it mean to be chosen by God?
- To what degree did the Holy Spirit guide the preservation of these narratives, and is there something sacred to be uncovered beneath all these human fingerprints?
- If the Bible has given voice to the oppressed, why is it also used as justification by their oppressors?

Drawing on the best in biblical scholarship and using her well-honed literary expertise, Evans examines some of our favorite Bible stories and possible interpretations, retelling them through memoir, original poetry, short stories, and even a short screenplay.

Undaunted by the Bible's most difficult passages and unafraid to ask the hard questions, Evans wrestles through the process of doubting, imagining, and debating the mysteries surrounding Scripture. Discover alongside Evans that the Bible is not a static text, but a living, breathing, captivating, and confounding book that can equip us and inspire us to join God's loving and redemptive work in the world.

— Amazon



**THRIVENT
FINANCIAL®**

Did you know... If you are a Thrivent member, you can contribute to First Lutheran Church through Thrivent Choice Dollars and Thrivent Actions Teams.

Log into your Thrivent account online, call 1-800-847-4836 or speak with your personal Thrivent representative for more information.

let's be friends



@FIRSTLUTHERANC



**FIRST LUTHERAN CHURCH
ELCA**

**Worship at First Evangelical Lutheran Church
is now at 8 and 10:30 Sunday mornings**



To those who helped with worship in June, including:
 McKenna Whelchel, Sherri Mannausau, Ardel Henrickson,
 Darrell Schmidt, Steve Saari, Duayne and Nancy Johnson,
 Becca and Deacon Schultz, Brian and Kallie Briggs, Diane
 McCarthy, Lynn Salo, Jeff Trask, Grace Weisz, George
 Boe, Carol Bass, Daryl and Teresa Waller
 To those who helped with fellowship.
 To those who helped with music: Kris Jackson, Sue
 Hewitt, Lynn Salo, and Kathy Thureen.

Prayer Chain

First Lutheran Church has four active prayer chains. If you have prayer requests for someone, or yourself, call either the church office at 283-2208, or Brenda Bertilson 283-2144; 240-4939. You must have permission to put someone on the chain, either from the person, or from a close relative. To put someone on the list for Sunday prayers, call the office at 283-2208. People will be on the list for one week only, unless you ask that they remain on the list. In that case, please call back when they can be removed.

Remember in your prayers, those in need and those in care facilities.

Good Samaritan: Jackie Christiansen, Margi Roeder, Ruby Radford, Lorraine Nelson,
 Barb (Strandberg) Wichner

Littlefork Nursing Home: Dick Bergh, Russel Millender

Northwinds Assisted Living: Vicki Freeberg, Terry Lucachick, Henry Carey

Ranier Roost: Ruth Millender

General Fund Financial Information

As of May 31, 2024

Thank you for supporting First Lutheran Church!

	Current Month Actual	Current Month Budget	Variance		Year To Date Actual	Year To Date Budget	Variance
Operating Income	9,098	15,891	(6,794)		69,095	79,455	(10,360)
Operating Expense	19,909	15,891	(4,018)		81,128	79,455	(1,673)
Operating Income Less Ex- pense	(10,811)	0	(10,811)		(12,034)	0	(12,034)

July Birthdays

7/2	Lyam Pelland	Korie Valentine	7/28	Patricia Ettestad	
7/3	Andrew Boelk	Jean Wood		Willard Johnson	
7/4	Harley Droba	7/18	Myles Mason	William Lyon	
	Carson Luettjohann		Camryn Rasmussen	7/29	Idella Franz
7/5	Owen Jensen	7/19	Gladys Brown		Barrett Olson
7/7	Harold Schumacher	7/20	Henry Carey		Tom Ollikkala
7/8	Darci Pelland		Kathryn Hughes	7/30	Calissa Treat
7/9	Cynthia Buller	7/21	Eric Earley		
	Andrew Eide		Hailey Strand		
	Donna Erickson	7/22	Ryan Skogstad		
7/10	Jeffrey Trask		Cynthia Warren		
7/11	Eileen Johnson	7/23	Amy Amundsen		
7/12	Tanya Anderson		Aimee Droba		
	Mary Jo Fischer		Mitchell Kapla		
	Rod Haanen	7/24	Jason Lindquist		
	Teresa Waller	7/25	Denise Franz		
7/13	Jenny Herman		Shay Mannausau		
7/14	John Slatinski V	7/26	Irving Arnquist		
7/16	Bunny Blaine		Brooklyn Sobkowicz		
	Leah Boe		Faye Whitbeck		
	Mindy Hraban	7/27	Kathryn Miggins		
7/17	Tyler Plasky		Steve Shermoen		

A two-tiered birthday cake is shown on the right side of the page. The bottom tier is decorated with pink frosting and yellow stars, and is surrounded by a ring of red berries. The top tier is smaller, with white frosting and yellow stars. A single lit candle with a yellow flame sits on top of the cake. The cake is placed on a light blue circular base.

BACKUS COMMUNITY CAFE SERVES FREE, HOT MEALS TO EVERYONE

**Call 218-283-7225 to reserve meals for you and your family for
dine-in from 5-6 on Tuesdays and Thursdays.
There is no charge, but donations are greatly appreciated.**

Thank you to June's volunteers:

Carol Bass, Penny Wakely, Nancy Johnson, and Brenda Bertilson

FIRST EVANGELICAL LUTHERAN CHURCH, ELCA
123 Wayside Lane
International Falls, MN 56649

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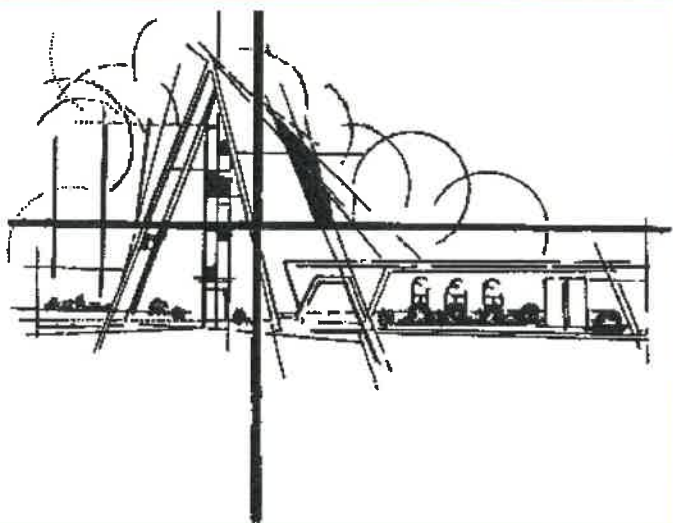
July 2024
NEWSLETTER

(CHANGE SERVICE REQUESTED)



First Evangelical Lutheran Church, ELCA

WHEREVER YOU ARE ON YOUR JOURNEY, YOU ARE WELCOME HERE!



First Lutheran's Mission Statement *Sharing God's Grace*

First Lutheran's Vision Statement *First Lutheran Church will be a congregation that shares God's grace by:*

- + Proclaiming the gospel of Jesus Christ with integrity.
- + Welcoming all to active involvement in ministry.
- + Offering a non-judgmental encounter with God through the celebration of liturgical worship with word and sacrament.
- + Responding faithfully to the Great Commission of Matthew 28 -- to grow.
- + Committing ourselves to serving the needs of our congregation and the community at large.

WORSHIP SERVICE

Available on our website
Sundays at 10:30 a.m.

OFFICE HOURS

Mon. through Fri., 9 a.m. to noon
Office: 218-283-2208

Check out our Website!

www.firstlutheranifalls.org

Look for us on Instagram and Facebook.